3.1 Spanish Colonial Rule

Imagine invaders from far away taking over your town. They would know little about your culture and would likely try to change it. When the Spanish claimed territory in the Americas, they forced a number of social and economic changes, many of which were far from positive.

MAIN IDEA Spanish colonial social and agricultural practices in the Americas had a dramatic effect on Native American cultures.

A SOCIAL PYRAMID

As you have read, to control such a huge and distant territory in the Americas, the king of Spain divided it into two viceroyalties. Viceroys governed New Spain and Peru from their capitals, Mexico City and Lima, respectively.

Society in Spanish colonies was hierarchical, or organized like a pyramid. Spanish-born people and their American-born children, called Creoles, were the smallest but most powerful group. **Mestizos** (mes-TEE-zohs), people of mixed Spanish and Native American ancestry, occupied the middle part of society. Native Americans and enslaved Africans were the least powerful but most numerous group.

The Spanish government gave the wealthiest Spanish colonists **haciendas** (hah-see-EHN-dah), or tracts of land to farm. On Caribbean islands, most haciendas were sugarcane **plantations**, or large farms. Sugarcane was an important crop from which colonists made sugar and molasses, which they traded with Europe.

With the hacienda came an **encomienda** (en-coe-mee-AYN-dah), a grant to owners of a certain number of Native American laborers. In return for their labor, the Native Americans received protection from enemies, but never any payment. Native Americans had little power within this social and labor system. Additionally, so many Native Americans died from working in hot and dangerous conditions that the Spanish began to import enslaved Africans to replace them.

IMPACT OF THE CHURCH

The Catholic Church played a major role in Spanish colonization by establishing hundreds of **missions**, or religious settlements, in the Americas. Priests and missionaries wanted to convert Native Americans to Christianity and they also taught skills such as masonry and carpentry.

Some priests brutally punished those who would not adopt Spanish culture. **Bartolomé de Las Casas**, a Spanish priest himself, wrote about the abuses of Native Americans that he'd witnessed. He convinced the Spanish king to pass laws to protect Native Americans from mistreatment, but landowners forced the reversal of those laws.

In 1680, a Pueblo leader named **Popé** led a revolt in present-day New Mexico and drove the Spanish from the area. Popé freed the region of Spanish influence, but Spain restored its control after his death in 1692. By 1700, Spain controlled much of the Americas and remained a powerful presence and a major social influence into the 1800s.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** Who were the mestizos and where did they fit in Spanish colonial society?
2. **COMPARE AND CONTRAST** How did the encomienda and mission systems compare?
3. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** How did the Spanish mission system affect Native American societies?

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AMERICAN PLACES

Carmel Mission, California

Founded in 1771, Carmel Mission served as the center of the Catholic mission system in California until 1834. Its founder, Father Junipero Serra, dedicated his life to building seven more missions in California. Today, visitors to the mission can tour an exhibit of his living quarters.

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